

Focus fronting, Q-Particles and anti-pied-piping¹

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In the classic analysis of A'-movement some A'-element—a *wh*-phrase, a focused phrase or a relative operator—moves to the specifier of a left-peripheral functional head. More recently Cable (2010) has developed a different view: the A'-bar element forms a constituent with a Q-Particle and it is that constituent that moves. Cable (2010) focuses on *wh*-questions but suggests (pp. 200-205) that the analysis can be extended to focus movement and relativization. Against this backdrop, we argue for a Q-Particle analysis of focus fronting in Kalaallisut (Inuit, Greenland) coupled with a Prosodic Inversion analysis of the second-position behavior of the focus clitic. Empirical support for a Q-Particle analysis over a classic analysis of focus fronting comes from focus marking of possessive DPs and from in-situ foci.

In addition to providing the first theoretical account of clitic placement in Kalaallisut focus fronting, the paper expands the empirical domain of what Branan and Erlewine (2023) call 'anti-pied-piping' in two ways. First, we document anti-pied-piping in possessive structures, which are not discussed in their paper. Second, while Branan and Erlewine (2023) discuss both second-position focus clitics and movement of entire foci, they do not discuss cases that combine the two, as is the case in Kalaallisut. Finally, the proposed analysis has implications for our understanding of coordinate structures in the language, which to our knowledge has received very little attention in the theoretical literature (though see Shuurman (2014) on coordination in closely related Inuktitut).

1 Background

Language ecology Kalaallisut is a member of the Inuit-Yupik-Unangan language family, which is spoken from Eastern Russia across Alaska and Canada to Greenland. It is the

¹Thanks to Richard Compton, Vera Gribanova, Boris Harizanov, Peter Jenks, Hannah Sande and Michelle Yuan for pointers to literature and discussion.

sole official language of Greenland, with around 50,000 speakers in Greenland and another 17,000 in Denmark (Naja Blytmann Trondhjem p.c.). The language is acquired by children in the home and taught in school. Danish is/was a colonial power in Greenland and Danish language has a big presence, especially in administration. English has a growing presence.

Two linguistic features—word order and clitics—are of immediate relevance for the arguments we make below.

Word order Based on an extensive corpus study, Fortescue (1993) makes a sustained argument that the unmarked word order in Kalaallisut is SOV, as in (1).^{2,3}

- (1) Naja-p Juuna ikior-paa.
 Naja-ERG Juuna.ABS help-3SG>3SG.IND
 Naja helped Juuna. Third Author AFX-1

This view is supported by elicitation, in which SOV order is always accepted and always volunteered in an out-of-the-blue context

Second position clitics Kalaallisut has a rich inventory of second position (2P) enclitics; see Molich (2022) for details and discussion of relevant literature. Most 2P enclitics have clause-level meaning and their domain is the CP. This is the case, for instance, for the discourse enclitic (=mi) in (2):⁴

²Elicited and volunteered examples are annotated with the name of the speaker and an alpha-numerical code identifying it in First Author's notebooks. Examples from the literature are adapted to current standard orthography and glossed in accordance with footnote 2.

³Glossing conventions: ABS = absolutive case; COP = copula; ERG = ergative case; FOC = focus; FUT = future; IND = indicative mood; INST = instrumental; PART = participial mood; PL = plural; SG = singular. 3SG>3SG.IND means third person singular subject acting on third person singular object in indicative mood. The morphological distinction between absolutive and ergative case is neutralized in plural and pronominal DPs. I gloss these for case based on their syntactic function.

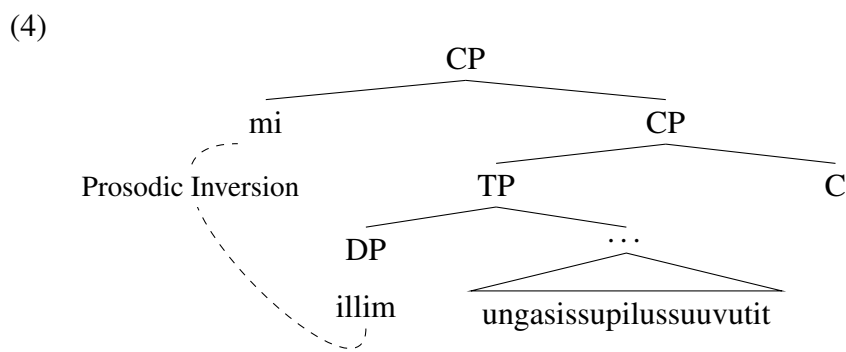
⁴Molich translates =mi with the Danish discourse particle *jo*, which is equally impossible to gloss and translate into English, so here I simply gloss =mi as =MI and leave it out of the translation. The important point here is its position, not its meaning.

- (2) [Illim=**mi** ungasissu-pilus-su-u-vutit_{CP}].
 2SG.ABS=MI far.away-colossal-big-COP-2SG.IND
 You are infinitely far away. (de Saint-Exupéry 2017:34 via Molich 2022:69)

For other 2P clitics the domain is smaller, e.g. DP. This is the case for =*taa*q ‘also’ in (3).⁵

- (3) [Inu-it=**taa**q taakku suliffi-isa illuta-at_{DP}]
 human-PL.ERG these.PL.ERG work.place-3PL>3PL.ERG house-3PL>3PL.ABS
 amerla-qi-su-tigut ajor-luinnar-put.
 many-very-nomZ-EQUA.PL be.bad-completely-3PL.IND
 [Also the physical surroundings of those people’s workplace] are in many ways
 very poor. (Sermitsiaq⁶ 11/15/2007 via Molich 2022:86)

=*mi* and =*taa*q are specifically 2W clitics in the sense of Halpern (1995:15): they are positioned after the first phonological word in their domain, which need not correspond to the maximal projection in their domain. In (2) the domain of =*mi* is the clause (Molich 2022:69), but =*mi* attaches to the first word of the clause. In (3) the syntactic domain of the clitic is the entire complex DP, but the clitic is realized on the first word of that DP. In the syntax these W2 clitics are generated above their host and then undergo PROSODIC INVERSION with the first phonological word to their right (Halpern 1995; King 1996:289-290). This analysis is illustrated for (2) in (4).⁷



⁵Possessors are marked with ergative case. 3PL>3PL.ERG means 3PL possessor with 3PL possessum in ergative case.

⁶Greenlandic newspaper.

⁷As pointed out to us by Boris Harizanow, it might also be possible to devise an analysis within Distributed Morphology using the operation Local Dislocation. Either analysis will support the argument we make in section 4.1. For concreteness we assume the prosodic inversion analysis throughout.

2 Focus fronting

Kalaallisut has a focus construction in which the focused element appears in initial position followed by an agreeing focus enclitic (=una for singular foci, =uku for plural foci) and the verb appears in the participial mood; see Fortescue (1984:74ff, 184ff), Molich (2022:100-107), and Mikkelsen et al. (2025). Recall that underlying word order is SOV. Also note that the focus clitics triggers nasalization of a host-final stop.

- (5) **Uagun=uku** Naja-p ikior-aatigut.
1.PL=FOC.PL Naja-ERG help-3SG>1PL.PART
It was US Naja helped.

Third Author CLT-2

For Second Author and Third Author, =una/=uku focus fronting is obligatory. Leaving =una/=uku and their host in situ is ungrammatical:

- (6) *Naja-p **uagun=uku** ikior-aatigut.
Naja-ERG 1PL.ABS=FOC.PL help-3SG>1PL.PART
Intended: It was US Naja helped.

Third Author CLT-3

It is similarly ungrammatical to front only =uku

- (7) ***Uku** Naja-p **uagut** ikior-aatigut.
FOC.PL Naja-ERG 1PL.ABS help-1SG>1PL.PART
Intended: It was US Naja helped.

Third Author CLU-1

It is also ungrammatical to front just the focused XP without =uku. This holds true whether =uku is realized as an independent word (8), undergoes prosodic inversion with the verb immediately to its right (9) or leans onto the immediately preceding subject (10).

- (8) *Uagut Naja-p **uku** ikior-raatigut
1PL.ABS Naja-ERG FOC.PL help-3SG>1PL.PART
It is US Naja helped.

Third Author CLU-3

- (9) Uagut Naja-p ikior-raatigun=**uku**
1PL.ABS Naja-ERG help-3SG>1PL.PART=FOC.PL
It is US Naja helped.

Third Author CLU-5

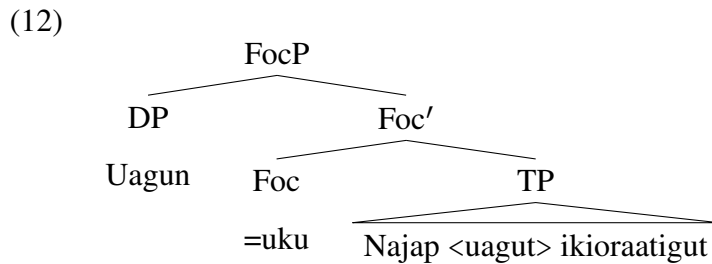
- (10) Uagut Naja-m=**uku** ikior-raatigut
 1PL.ABS Naja-ERG=FOC.PL help-3SG>1PL.PART
 It is US Naja helped.

Third Author CLU-2

This focus fronting pattern is summarized in (11).

(11) FRONTING	GRAMMATICALITY
clitic & focused phrase	✓
clitic only	✗
focused phrase only	✗
neither	✗

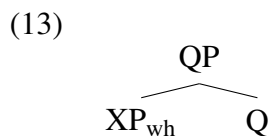
Under a classic analysis of A'-movement, (5) would have the derivation in (12).



On this analysis the adjacency of =*uku* to its host is the result of syntactic movement of the host to the specifier of the projection headed by the focus clitic (King 1996, Weisser 2025 a.o.).

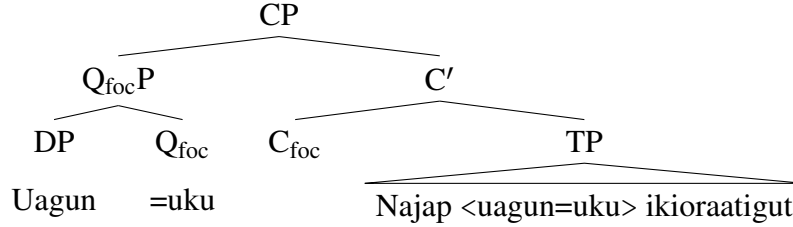
3 Q-Particle analysis

Cable (2010) offers very different analysis of A'-movement, based on a case study of Tlingit (Na Dene, Alaska) *wh*-questions. Instead of the question particle (Q-Particle) heading a functional projection on the clausal spine, the question particle takes the *wh*-phrase as its complement forming a QP, as in (13).



The QP moves to a left-peripheral position taking the *wh*-phrase with it. Transposing Cable’s analysis of Tlingit *wh*-movement to Kalaallisut focus fronting, (5) has the derivation in (14).⁸

(14)



While they posit very different derivations for focus fronting, the classic theory of A'-movement and the Q-Particle theory both account for basic cases of focus fronting like (5). Next we look at phenomena that differentiate the two approaches in favor of the Q-Particle analysis.

4 Two arguments for a QP analysis

We offer two arguments in support of the Q-Particle analysis of focus fronting based on focus fronting of possessive DPs and the possibility of in-situ focus.

4.1 Focus fronting of possessive DPs

Kalaallisut possessive DPs consists of a, possibly null, possessor followed by the possessum.

- (15) angut-ip qimmi-i
man-ERG dog-3SG>3PL.ABS
the man's dogs

Third Author BOP-4

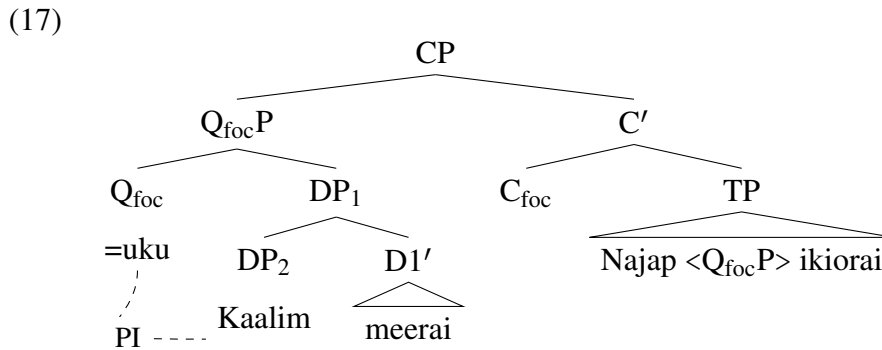
When overt, the possessor is marked with ergative case. The possessum bears a portman-teaux suffix that indicates i) number and person of the possessor, ii) number of the possessum and iii) case. When a possessive DP is focus fronted the enclitic is hosted by the

⁸The headedness of $Q_{foc}P$ will be revised in section 4.1.

possessor, as opposed to the expected position after the possessum.⁹ We see this in (16), where the scope of focus is the entire possessive DP, as indicated by the plural agreement, but its host is the possessor.

- (16) [**Kaali-m=uku** **meera-i**] Naja-p ikior-ai.
 Kaali-ERG=FOC.PL meera-3SG>3PL.ABS Naja-ERG help-3SG>3PL.PART
 It was KAALI'S CHILDREN that Naja helped. Second Author CGR-GS-1

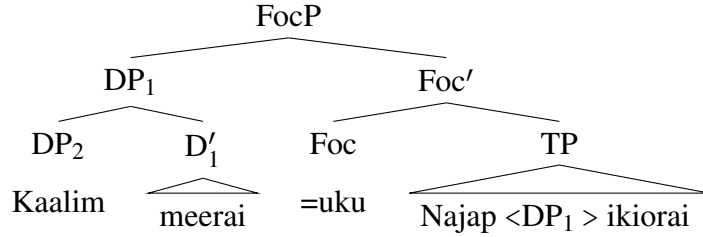
This placement of the focus clitic is anti-pied-piping in the sense of Branan and Erlewine (2023): focus is marked on a proper subpart of the semantic focus. Under the QP analysis of focus fronting, this configuration follows from three assumptions: i) $Q_{\text{foc}}P$ moves to the specifier of a left-peripheral C_{foc} head, ii) $Q_{\text{foc}}P$ is head-initial and iii) $=una/=uku$ are 2P clitics that undergo prosodic inversion with the first phonological word to their right. Collectively these assumptions result in the derivation of (16) in (17). PI stands for Prosodic Inversion.



Under the classic analysis prosodic inversion would proceed from the structure in (18).

⁹For Second Author, the possessor is the only acceptable host for the clitic. Third Author sometimes alternatively allows the clitic to be hosted by the possessum. Anticipating the analysis below, this is because $=uku$ may invert with the entire possessive DP as opposed to the phonological word in grammar of Second Author. See Branan and Erlewine (2023:617ff), Fortescue (1984:312) and Weisser (2025) for relevant discussion.

(18)

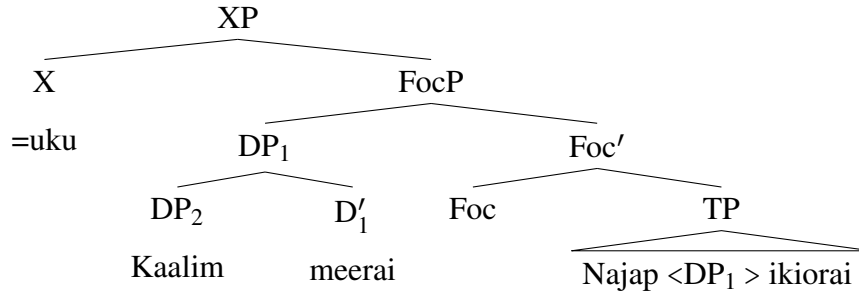


Since =uku is a 2P clitic and undergoes prosodic inversion with the element immediately to its right, the expected outcome is the ungrammatical (19):

- (19) *[**Kaali-p meera-i**] Naja-m=uku ikior-ai.
 Kaali-ERG meera-3SG>3PL.ABS Naja-ERG=FOC.PL help-3SG>3PL.PART
 Intended: It was KAALI'S CHILDREN that Naja helped. Third Author CLV-1

Prosodic inversion can't derive (16) under the classic analysis because the focus phrase is *higher* in the structure than the focus clitic, so there is no way for the focus clitic to lower onto the possessor. One could try to save the classic analysis by adding a projection about FocP that is headed by =uku, as in (20).¹⁰

(20)



In this structure, the possessor *is* lower than =uku and =uku can lower onto it. However, this is entirely ad hoc: the only function of the added head is to provide a higher head position for =uku. In contrast both Q_{foc} and C_{foc} are motivated on the Q-Particle analysis: Q_{foc} manages the focus alternatives, specifically encoding exhaustivity (Cable 2010:200-205), and C_{foc} triggers movement of Q_{foc}P to its specifier.

¹⁰A second alternative is to try to extend Weisser's (2025) Distributed Integration analysis of clitic placement in coordination to possessive structures. For reasons of space we will not undertake that here.

4.2 Optional focus fronting

Recall that focus fronting is obligatory for Second Author and Third Author.

- (21) *Illit **meeqqa-n=uku** ikior-itit.
2SG.ERG child-PL.ABS=FOC.PL help-2SG>3PL.PART
Intended: It was THE CHILDREN you helped. Second Author BNX-GS-2

However, Fortescue (1984) and Molich (2022) present text examples where the focused phrase is not clause-initial. In (22) the focus marked interrogative phrase *qassi-nik* ‘how many-INST’ follows the subject.

- (22) Saara **qassi-nik=una** ukio-qa-ler-niar-toq?
Sara.ABS how.many-INST=FOC year-have-soon-FUT-3SG.PART
How old is Sara going to be? Thygesen 1984 via Molich 2022:104 ex 120

Similarly, in the embedded clause in (23), the focus marked subject *Hansi* follows the adverb *taamani* ‘at that time’.

- (23) Eqqaama-vara [taamani **Hansi=una** pisorta-a-soq].
remember-1SG>3SG.IND at.that.time Hansi.ABS leader-COP-3SG.PART
I remember Hansi was the leader at that time Fortescue 1984:189.

These are very difficult to account for on the classic analysis, where *=una* is a high head on the clausal spine; only left peripheral material should be able precede it. The Q-Particle analysis offers a straightforward account: for the authors of (22) and (23) focus fronting is optional. Hence in (22) and (23) the $Q_{\text{foc}}P$ surfaces in-situ with prosodic inversion of the focus particle and the focused XP. For Second Author and Third Author, on the other hand, focus fronting is obligatory.

5 A puzzle about coordination

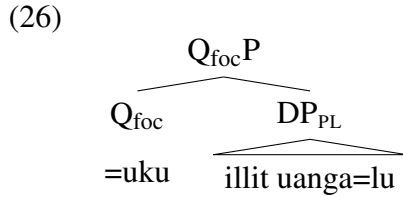
Coordination is another type of complex DP where we might expect to see 2P effects (Weisser 2025 and references cited there). As expected, the focus enclitic cannot be hosted by the second conjunct:

- (24) *[illit uanga=lu]=uku angerla-jaar-tugut.
 2SG 1SG=and=FOC.PL come.home-early-1PL.PART
 Intended: It was you and me that came home early. Third Author CLV-3

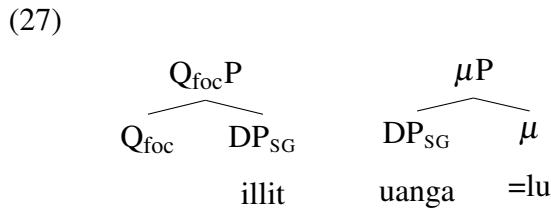
Surprisingly, it is equally impossible for =uku to be hosted by the first conjunct:

- (25) *[Ilin=uku uanga=lu] angerla-jaar-tugut.
 2SG=FOC.PL 1SG=and come.gome-early-1PL.PART
 It was you and me that came home early. Third Author BOK-4

The ungrammaticality of (25) is unexpected on the Q-Particle with prosodic inversion analysis: if phrase-initial =uku takes the entire plural conjunction as its complement, as in (26), it should be able to undergo prosodic inversion with the first conjunct, but it cannot.



To resolve this tension, we hypothesize that the string *illit uanga=lu* in (24) and (25) is not actually a coordination but rather consists of two uncoordinated phrases—a DP (*illit* ‘you’) and a freestanding additive phrase (*uanga=lu* ‘also me’)—that do not form a constituent together. This proposal can be contextualized within Mitrović and Sauerland’s (2014) theory of coordination. They posit two distinct types of coordinators: J-coordinators and μ -coordinators, where μ -coordinators have additive uses. Following Shuurman’s (2014) analysis of =lu in closely-related Inuktitut, we hypothesize that =lu is a μ head. With these two assumptions in place we can diagram *illit uanga=lu* as in (27).



Under this analysis of *illit uanga=lu*, there is no plural DP to sponsor =uku in (25) and (24). Thus there is no way to derive these sentences, which explains their ungrammaticality.

(28) a. A: Naja aqagu Nuum-mukar-poq.
Naja.ABS tomorrow Nuuk-go.to-3SG.IND
Naja is going to Nuuk tomorrow. Second Author CLZ-GS-4

b. B: uanga=lu.
1SG=and
Me too. Second Author CLZ-GS-5

(29) Illin=una uanga=lu angerla-jaar-tugut.
2SG=FOC 1SG=and come.home-early-1PL.PART
It was you and me that came home early. Third Author BOK-3

The third piece of evidence that *illit* and *uanga* do not form a coordinate structure in (24) and (25) comes from extraction. If *illit uanga=lu* were a true coordination we would expect extraction of *illit* to be ungrammatical, because it would violate the Coordinate Structure Constraint. However extraction of the initial phrase is quite often accepted, as in (31).¹¹

¹¹This type of example was accepted on 5 out of 8 occasions. By contrast, Left Branch Extraction from possessive structures in comparable sentence structures was accepted on only one out of 12 occasions.

If the *=lu* construction is not a coordinate structure the Coordinate Structure Constraint does not apply. What would still need to be explained is why left-phrase extraction is sometimes judged ungrammatical. We suspect that processing might play a role.

6 Conclusion

We have substantiated Cable’s (2010:200-205) hypothesis that the Q-Particle analysis of *wh*-interrogatives can be extended to focus fronting. This complements Márquez’s (2024) Q-Particle analysis of relative clauses in Nuntajiiyi (Soque, Mexico). Our work, together with that of Cable (2010) and Márquez (2024), demonstrates that the Q-Particle theory has broad empirical support. Specifically, it allows for a unified analysis of three major A’-movement constructions in languages from distinct language families and differing typological profiles.¹²

We presented two arguments for a Q-Particle analysis of Kalaallisut focus fronting over a classic analysis. First the Q-Particle offers a straightforward account of the immediately post-possessor position of the enclitic in possessive DPS, whereas the classic analysis has to posit a functional head with no independent justification. Second, the classic analysis cannot account for the possibility of non-initial *=una/=uku*-marked foci for some speakers.

Our analysis extends the empirical scope of what Branan and Erlewine (2023) call ‘anti-pied-piping’—focus marking of a subpart of the semantic focus—to possessives, which are not discussed in their paper. We furthermore documented a novel constellation of morpho-syntactic focus marking: focus movement of the entire focus and focus marking of a subpart of the focus.¹³ Finally our 2P analysis of focus clitic placement provides a new perspective on Kalaallisut coordinations, which have not received much attention.

¹²Additionally, Hedding (2022) provides a unified Q-Particle analysis of *wh*-questions and focus movement in San Martín Peras Mixtec (Otomanguean, Mexico).

¹³While Branan and Erlewine (2023:614-615) discuss 2P focus clitics in Latin, Tagalog and Thompson River Salish, these not paired with movement of the entire focus.

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